

By Subhash Mishra

At Amhat town in Sultanpur district, about 135 km from Lucknow, a new and well-furnished guesthouse has come up on the national highway. Inaugurated by then district magistrate Sanjay Kumar, it's a special place, meant only to be used by senior state bureaucrats. "*Yeh guesthouse to DM aur Commissioner sahib ke liye hi hai* (this guesthouse is meant for the DM and Commissioner)," an official from the district magistrate's office told INDIA TODAY. Another such building has come up in Varanasi. In fact, several other structures of a similar nature, called Rifle Club guesthouses or Rifle Club offices, have sprung up across the state. And that's where the trouble begins.

The magistrates of almost all the districts in Uttar Pradesh have col-

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Rifle Club donations by arms licence holders are used to finance a growing network of guesthouses instead of providing training infrastructure and promoting shooting

lected crores of rupees under the head of Rifle Club "donation". Strangely, proper accounts of these donations or how these funds are being spent have not been maintained. Buildings have come up as resthouses exclusively for IAS officers which are being mostly used by the families of these officers for rest and recreation. What's worse, in several districts, the Rifle Clubs do not exist at all though donations have been collected. In other words, public money is being used illegally by the DMS and the Government has no knowledge about it.

Last year, when an advocate of the Allahabad High Court, Shishir Tandon, sought information about these Rifle Clubs under the RTI Act, no response came from the district magistrate's office of Allahabad. "While

seeking a license for a firearm, I was asked to deposit Rs 500 as the fee for the Rifle Association. I was not given any receipt," says Tandon, who wants to know the exact amount collected by the district magistrate as fee for the Rifle Association, how this money is being spent and what exactly the functions of this association are. "Almost all the DMS know the money has been squandered and not spent on the Rifle Association. So they have to conceal the information," says Anugrah Narain Singh, Congress MLA. He adds, however, that the misuse has happened not only during the Mayawati regime but it has been going on for a long time. "Under Mayawati, the DMS have increased the fee arbitrarily," he says.

The Rifle Club donation practice

dates back to the British period when every district had a District Rifle Association (DRA), popularly called the Rifle Club, which was established to provide basic infrastructure to arms license holders for learning how to handle weapons. The DRAs were also supposed to promote the sport of shooting in the public. The British collectors took less than a rupee as DRA fee for creating a corpus fund to ensure proper infrastructure, ammunition and a firing range. Post Independence, the fee of the Rifle Club was enhanced and it was made mandatory. From time to time the fee was raised arbitrarily and district magistrates stopped giving receipts for these donations. "I have paid Rs 2,000 as Rifle Club fee, but the clerk in the collector's office refused to